

KITCHEN

Herbalism





WHAT IS AN HERBALIST?

An herbalist is a person who uses plants, herbs, and spices for medicinal purposes. They are experts in the field of natural medicine and can provide guidance on how to use plants to heal a wide range of conditions. Herbalism is an ancient practice that has been used for centuries in many different cultures around the world. It is a holistic approach to healing that focuses on the whole person, rather than just treating symptoms.

Herbalists use a variety of plants to create remedies that can help with everything from minor ailments like colds and headaches to more serious conditions like chronic pain and autoimmune disorders. They may also create custom blends of herbs to address specific health concerns or to support overall wellness.

One of the benefits of working with an herbalist is that they can help you develop a deeper understanding of your body and how it works. They may provide guidance on diet and lifestyle changes that can support your overall health and wellbeing. They can also help you navigate the complex world of plant medicine, which can be overwhelming for those who are new to the practice.

In addition to their expertise in herbal medicine, many herbalists are passionate advocates for sustainable and ethical sourcing of the plants they use. They may work with local farmers or cultivate their own plants to ensure that they are using high-quality ingredients that are grown in an environmentally responsible way.

Overall, working with an herbalist can be a transformative experience that can help you achieve optimal health and wellbeing. Whether you are dealing with a chronic condition or simply looking to support your overall health, an herbalist can provide guidance and support that can help you achieve your goals.

WHAT IS HERBALISM?

Herbalism is a time-honored practice that involves using plants and plant extracts to aid and support the human body's natural processes. The history of herbalism is fascinating, and it dates back to ancient times when humans first discovered the properties of various plants. People across many cultures throughout the world have been using herbal preparations for centuries, making it a primary form of medicine in many parts of the world.

For example, in Greece, herbal medicine was an essential part of their culture, with famous physicians like Hippocrates using herbs in their recipes. Similarly, in China, herbal medicine has been practiced for more than two thousand years and is still widely used today. Native American cultures also have a long history of using herbs to aid and support the body.

Throughout history, herbalists have developed a deep understanding of how different plants can be used to aid and support different body systems. They have learned which plants have anti-inflammatory properties, which ones can help with anxiety, and which ones can help with digestion, among many other things.

In modern times, herbalism is still a popular form of alternative medicine. People seek out herbal preparations to supplement traditional medical treatments, and some herbalists even work in conjunction with medical doctors to provide supplement care to patients. Herbal preparations can be used to support the immune system, manage stress and anxiety, improve digestion, and help the body recover from illness or injury.

In conclusion, the history of herbalism is a rich and fascinating one, and the practice of using plants and plant extracts to aid and support the body continues to be popular today. With an increasing interest in natural remedies and holistic approaches to wellness, herbalism is likely to remain a relevant and important practice for years to come.

WHAT IS AN HERB?

The dictionary gives the word ‘herb’ two definitions. (1) a seed producing plant that does not develop woody tissue that dies down at the end of the growing season (2) a plant or plant part valued for its medicinal, savory, and aromatic purposes. The second definition is the one that I will be referring to throughout this course.

A ‘plant or plant part or plant material’ means that an herb can be a tree, shrub, root, fruit, seed, flower, or any other part of the plant except the dirt, as long as it is used for medicinal purposes.

For the purpose of this course, we are interested in herbs that are used for natural health purposes. I will throughout this course refer to all plants as an herb. I believe that all plants have some sort of medicinal use, bad or good, whether we know a purpose or not.

There are a lot of theories, statements regarding if herbs really do hold any dietary properties. Each herbalist, layperson in the natural health (alternative) world has their own beliefs and teaching when it comes to the uses of the plant and the active component or live component or constituents found in each plant source. For this course it will be stated and known that plants can contain properties that can be used for aiding natural health.

According to Dr. Earl Mindell there are 380,000 species of plants that have been identified, and several hundred thousand that have not yet been discovered. Out of these 380,000 plants about 260,000 have been classified as higher plants, meaning that they contain chlorophyll and perform a certain process called photosynthesis. All of these plants listed in the higher plant group have the potential to offer medicinal benefits. However, only 10 percent have actually been studied for medicinal purposes.

Herbs have been used for centuries by various traditional medicine systems like Ayurveda, Chinese medicine, and indigenous cultures. These systems use herbs and plants for their potential health benefits and preventative abilities. Herbs can be used in different forms like teas, tinctures, capsules, and as whole foods. They can be used to support the immune system, improve digestion, reduce inflammation, improve sleep, alleviate anxiety and depression, and much more.

Many scientific studies have also shown the potential health benefits of herbs. For example, turmeric contains curcumin, which has anti-inflammatory properties and has been shown to reduce the risk of chronic diseases like cancer and Alzheimer's. Ginger has been found to have anti-nausea properties and can be used to alleviate motion sickness.

However, it is important to note that herbs should not be used as a substitute for medical treatment or medication. It is always recommended to consult with a qualified healthcare provider before starting any herbal remedies, especially if you have any pre-existing medical conditions or taking any medications. Overall, herbs can hold potential dietary properties and can be used as part of a holistic approach to natural health.

The NCCAM is also a great resource to learn about traditional medicines and practices from around the world, and their potential benefits and risks. They offer a variety of information on herbal supplements, including their uses, potential side effects and interactions, and dosages. It is important to note that just because something is natural or derived from a plant, it does not necessarily mean that it is safe or effective without further research and testing.

It is always important to consult with a healthcare professional before starting any new herbal supplement or alternative therapy, especially if you are taking any medications or have any health conditions. While herbs can provide many benefits, they can also interact with medications and cause potential harm, so it is important to approach them with caution and under the guidance of a professional.

i**INTRODUCTION OF HERBS**

An herb is a plant used for its phytochemicals, which are the active compounds found within the plant. Plants have an almost limitless ability to create aromatic substances, most of which are phenols or their oxygen-substituted derivatives such as tannins. In many cases, these substances, especially alkaloids, serve as plant defense mechanisms. Many of the herbs and spices used by humans to season food yield useful health components as well.

The use of and search for drugs and dietary supplements derived from plants has grown in recent years. Pharmacologists, microbiologists, botanists, and natural-products chemists are combining what could be developed for the treatment of various diseases. The potential benefits of herbal medicine are being explored more and more.

Some herbalists refer to all medicinal plants, trees, vines, weeds, shrubs, mosses, etc., that contain medicinal properties as 'herbs'. Regardless of species or family, some herbalists believe that all plants hold medicinal properties. This belief is based on the idea that plants have evolved over millions of years to produce a wide variety of chemical compounds in order to defend against predators, attract pollinators, and compete with other plants for resources. Thus, even plants that are not traditionally considered medicinal may still have properties that could be useful for human health.

Herbal preparations is a type of complementary and alternative to traditional medicine that has been recognized as an effective treatment method by the scientific community. Although herbal remedies are generally considered safe in North America, they are classified as dietary supplements by law, which means that the manufacturing standards for these products are not as stringent as those required for pharmaceutical drugs. As a result, some herbal remedies may not meet the same safety and efficacy standards as pharmaceutical drugs.

However, despite the limitations imposed by law, many manufacturers still advertise the supposed benefits of herbal remedies extensively through third-party advertising in magazines and through company representatives. While manufacturers can only make a few "structure and function" claims, some work around that limitation by using creative marketing techniques to promote their products.

DEFINING HERBS

Despite the differences in legal classification and physician training, the public's interest in alternative therapies for general health maintenance and supportive treatment of chronic diseases has increased tremendously. This growing interest has spurred further research into the efficacy and safety of herbals, and has led to the development of new and innovative treatment methods.

Defining herbs is a crucial aspect of understanding their properties and uses. One way to define an herb is through plant classification, which organizes the characteristics of an herb into smaller categories such as family, genus, species, hybrid, variety, subspecies, form, and cultivar.

The family of an herb refers to a group of related plants, while the genus refers to a group of related species. Species, on the other hand, refers to a group of similar plants. Hybrid, as the name suggests, is a cross between two plants. Variety, subspecies, and form are subdivisions of hybrid species. The cultivar, meanwhile, is a plant produced and maintained by cultivation with the same characteristics of habit, color, and flavor.

When it comes to identifying herbs, the Latin and common names come in handy. Different cultures may have the same herb with a different common name, but the scientific name will remain consistent. This is how we classify herbs consistently across nations.

Overall, understanding the classification of herbs is essential for anyone interested in their properties and uses. By knowing the different categories of herbs and how they are classified, we can better understand their unique characteristics and benefits.

BRIEF HISTORY OF HERBALISM

The use of plants as herbal preparation dates back to the beginning of Earth. Through trial and error, Adam and Eve and their descendants discovered that some plants are good for food, some are poisonous, and some produce bodily changes such as increased perspiration, bowel movements, urination, relief of pain, hallucination, and healing. Over time, these observations were passed down from generation to generation, and every culture developed a body of herbal knowledge as part of its tradition.

Each culture has its own specific knowledge of herbal preparation, along with common names being passed down through the generations. For example, one culture may use mistletoe for treating cancer while others may not.

- Native Americans in the realm of herbal medicine using the herbs found in their own backyards. Many colonists suffered from and witnessed plagues and pestilence in Europe, so they became eager students of Native American herbal medicine and foraging (wild harvesting) for herbs.
    - In 1536, a Native American gave sick explorers a tea brewed from yellow cedar bark and leaves to aid in what they called scurvy, and they all recovered.
    - Native Americans introduced white settlers to many valuable herbs, including black cohosh, black haw, boneset, cascara sagrada, Echinacea, chaparral, goldenseal, lobelia, Oregon grape, sarsaparilla, slippery elm, wild cherry, and witch hazel, to name just a few.

Herbs were a major colonial export, alongside furs, tobacco, and cotton. However, nothing beat ginseng, the herb native to Asia, in terms of profitability. The French began shipping ginseng to China in the early 1700s, and it eventually spread to all 13 colonies, selling for $1.00 a pound. Surprisingly, the search for ginseng led to the exploration and discovery of Pennsylvania, West Virginia, Kentucky, and Tennessee. Daniel Boone was a native ginseng collector, and Constantine S. Rafinesque, a European botanist, came to the Mississippi Valley to study with Indian healers before becoming a botany professor at a college in KY.

Samuel Thompson studied with Native Americans and midwife healers. When his daughter became seriously ill, doctors pronounced her incurable, but she was cured with a hot bath and some herbs. Thompson went on to create a System of Botanic Practice of Medicine.

In 1820, two-thirds of the treatments in the U.S. were botanical, and by 1880, that number had risen to three-quarters. However, by the 20th century, pharmaceutical drugs had replaced herbal medicine. Nonetheless, some drugs are still derived from herbs.

- MesopotamiaThe first known written record of herbal medicine was made over five thousand years ago by the Sumerians in ancient Mesopotamia (present-day Iraq).
- China
- The roots of Chinese medicine, which is based largely on herbalism, also date back approximately 5,000 years.
- India
- The Indian system of medicine was called Ayurveda. The Indian materia medica, or list of herbs used as medicines was extensive. Indian herbalism, or Ayurveda, is still practiced today.
- Greeks and Romans
- The Greek physician Hippocrates (c.460 - 377 BC), often called the "Father of Modern Medicine," was an herbalist. He is known for having written, "Let your Foods be your medicines, and your medicines your food."

- Middle Ages, Europe, and America
  - During the Middle Ages, the knowledge of medicinal plants was furthered by monks in Europe who studied and grew medicinal plants, and of course, translated the information down from generation to generation.
  - When the Europeans first came to America, they discovered that the Native Americans had knowledge of herbs. This type of knowledge is referred to as shamanism. A priest, or shaman.
  - Some say that when Lewis and Clark made their famous expedition westward from the Mississippi River, one of their duties was to learn from the Native Americans about their herbs.
- Nicholas Culpepper
  - "A man for all seasons" first opened an apothecary in 1640, where he sold low-cost botanical medicine. He published two works: The English Physician People's Herbal and an English translation of the Latin Pharmacopeia.
- The Shakers
  - Ann Lee, an English Shaker, was known for her medicinal herbs. Her motto was "hands to work, heart to God." Shakers sold herbs by catalogs. The Shakers also invented the modern pill by packing the powdered herb into a wooden mold, selling millions.
- Thomas Botanic Medicine
  - Samuel Thomson studied with midwives and Indian healers. Thomson's daughter became ill, and medical doctors gave up on her, but Thomson healed her with an herbal bath. His approach was called heroic medicine, using laxatives, bloodletting, and the use of mercury.

DEFINITIONS

Herbal Preparation: A time-honored system of healing practiced in every culture in the world. Science has modernized the system using analytical and pharmaceutical testing. The science-based practice of herbal medicine is now called phytomedicine or phytotherapy, which is a system of therapeutics in which diseases and disorders are treated with medicinal plants and preparations made from them using scientific principles.

‘Medicinal’ herbs: Medicinal products whose active ingredients consist exclusively of medicinal plants and preparations made from them. Using modern chemical and pharmaceutical methods, a number of popular herbal remedies are nowadays "standardized" to provide consistent levels of proven identified active compounds.

Phytochemistry: The study of plant chemistry, including the identification, isolation, analysis, and characterization of plant constituents, and determination of the chemical structures of plant constituents.

Pharmaceutical biology: The field of research concerned with the extraction and development of biogenic drugs from plants and other living organisms, as well as the processing and application of these drugs.

Phytopharmacology: The study of the uptake, distribution, and effect of herbal preparations and of their elimination from the body.

Active principles: Substances or substance groups definable by chemical analysis that essentially contribute to the therapeutic action of a medicinal herbal preparation. These active principles can be isolated and used for developing new pharmaceutical drugs.

Active ingredients of medicinal herbal preparations: Plant ingredients in their natural states and preparations made from them. These ingredients are the basis for the therapeutic effects of herbal medicine.

Minor constituents: Substances that have an indirect or slight effect on the therapeutic action of an herbal drug. Although they may not be as potent as active principles, they can still contribute to the overall therapeutic effect of herbal preparation.

Single-herb herbal preparation: Herbal medicinal preparation from one medicinal plant. These preparations are often used in traditional herbal medicine practices.

Target constituents: Herbal drug preparation constituents definable by chemical analysis that are used as parameters of in-process quality control and may contribute to a characteristic pharmaceutical property. Identifying and controlling target constituents in herbal preparations is important for ensuring their quality and efficacy.

Species, genus, family: Taxonomic terms classifying a plant. A genus may include one or more species, and a family may include one or more genera. Understanding the taxonomy of plants is important for identifying and using medicinal plants in herbal medicine.

HOW DO HERBS WORK?

Plants' living cells take in materials such as carbon dioxide, water, and sunlight, and convert them into useful nutrients, including by-products such as oxygen. Herbs contain phytochemicals, naturally occurring plant substances that can protect against disease, among other benefits. These compounds make herbs effective as drugs for treating disease. The plant's components, such as seeds, leaves, roots, flowers, stems, etc., contain active ingredients called phytochemicals that give the plant its medicinal properties. You will learn more about phytochemicals later in this course.

Many herbs contain antioxidants that fight off free radicals, harmful by-products of energy production. You will also learn more about free radicals later in this course.

In addition to phytochemicals and antioxidants, herbs contain other active compounds or components such as:

- Acids: They are sour, antiseptic, and cleansing.
- Alkaloids: They are bitter, affect the central nervous system, and can be extremely toxic in excess.
- Bitters: They have a very bitter taste, stimulate the gallbladder and liver, improving digestion and appetite.
- Coumarins: They are antibacterial and anticoagulant, but can be toxic in excess.
- Flavonoids: They can be bitter or sweet, anti-inflammatory, antibiotic, and antioxidant.
- Glycosides: They are cardiac, antispasmodic, sedative, and antibiotic.
- Gums and mucilage: They are sticky, slimy, smoothing, and softening.
- Quinones: They are antibacterial and antifungal.
- Resins: They are bound with oils, astringent, antiseptic, and healing.
- Saponins: They are anti-inflammatory, diuretic, and stimulant.
- Tannins: They are astringent, antiseptic, and detoxify tissue.
- Volatile oils: They are aromatic, antiseptic, fungicide, irritant, and stimulant, or essential oils.

People have used herbs for many purposes, not just for cooking (culinary herbs), but also for medicinal, household, beauty, as a hair rinse, and many other uses.

Whether you use herbs for culinary or medicinal purposes, you must know their properties before using them in recipes or for herbal preparations. Just because herbs are natural substances doesn't mean they are safe. Herbs can be strong preparations, and some herbs have been known to cause death. Before trying herbal medicine, make sure you know the herb you are using, its uses, side effects, cautions, and interactions with other drugs, including OTC and prescription drugs. Children, the elderly, and pregnant women should be careful when using, eating, or handling herbs.

HERBS SUBSTANCES

Herbs are a wonderful and natural source of plant-based nutrition. Within our world, there are a vast array of herbal alternative systems that have been developed throughout history. For instance, some popular types of these systems include European, Native American, Chinese, Ayurvedic, and Western herbalism. All of these systems share a common approach to treating the body as a whole and use the energy of herbs to work in synergy with the natural energy in each individual.

The benefits of incorporating herbs into your daily routine are truly remarkable. By utilizing herbs, you can provide your body with a natural, vital energy to do things you enjoy while also supporting your body's innate immune system. Furthermore, herbs are often high in vitamins, minerals, and other nutrients that nourish and build the body. By consuming herbs, you can also provide your body with the extra support it needs to aid in the normal functions of the human body.

One of the most fascinating things about herbs is how they absorb substances from the soil and convert them into essential nutrients such as vitamins, minerals, carbohydrates, proteins, and fats. These vital nutrients are what our bodies use for nourishment and natural healing. By utilizing whole herbs, we are able to take in all of the vital ingredients they carry. Most herbs contain several active substances, one of which usually dominates and determines its choice as an herbal alternative.

In conclusion, herbs are an incredibly diverse and powerful tool for promoting overall health and well-being. By incorporating herbal alternatives into your daily routine, you can help nourish your body with the vital nutrients it needs to thrive.

BIOLOGICAL BACKGROUND OF HERBS

All plants produce chemical compounds as part of their normal metabolic activities. These compounds can be split into sugars and fats, which are found in all plants, and active components, referred to earlier.

Furthermore, these active components can be found in various parts of the plant, such as leaves, stems, and flowers. For example, some herbs act as toxins to defend against prey or to attract insects for pollination. The Indian Blanket Flower, a type of herb, has little-known medicinal properties but can also repel deer from a garden if planted near the perimeter.

In addition, these active components can have therapeutic actions in humans and can be refined or synthesized to produce drugs. Inulin, for instance, is found in many plants and is the basis of insulin, which is used to manage diabetes. Quinine, derived from the bark of the cinchona tree, is used to treat malaria. Morphine and codeine, both derived from the poppy plant, are used to alleviate pain. Digoxin, found in the foxglove plant, is used to treat heart conditions.

Therefore, it is important to recognize the various functions of these chemical compounds produced by plants and their potential benefits in human health and medicine.

Moreover, the use of plant-derived drugs has a long history in traditional medicine. For example, Native Americans have used the bark of the willow tree, which contains salicylic acid, to relieve pain and fever. Today, salicylic acid is a key ingredient in aspirin, a widely used pain reliever.

Similarly, Chinese traditional medicine has long used ginkgo biloba, a tree native to China, to treat various ailments. Studies have shown that ginkgo biloba extract may improve cognitive function and alleviate symptoms of anxiety and depression.

In recent years, there has been a growing interest in plant-derived drugs as a source of new medications. Researchers are exploring the potential of thousands of plant species and their chemical compounds for various medical applications, such as cancer treatment, pain relief, and anti-inflammatory drugs.
However, it is important to note that plant-derived drugs can have side effects and may interact with other medications. Therefore, it is essential to consult a healthcare professional before using any plant-derived drugs or supplements.
In conclusion, the chemical compounds produced by plants have a wide range of functions and potential benefits in human health and medicine. With further research and development, plant-derived drugs may offer new solutions to various medical challenges.

HERBS WORK SYNERGISTICALLY

Herbs work together synergistically, so combining them can enhance each herb's properties and bring greater support to the body. For instance, a good mixture to promote relaxation combines Passiflora, valerian, and hops. All three herbs have relaxant properties, but Passiflora specializes in aiding sleep, valerian relaxes muscle tension, and hops have a marked effect on relaxing the nervous system.
Herbs have been used for centuries to promote health and wellness in individuals. It is well-known that combining herbs can enhance their properties and bring greater support to the body. In fact, the synergistic effect of combining different herbs has been noted to be much more effective than using a single herb alone.
For instance, a good mixture to promote relaxation combines Passiflora, valerian, and hops. All three herbs have relaxant properties, but Passiflora specializes in aiding sleep, valerian relaxes muscle tension, and hops have a marked effect on relaxing the nervous system. The combination of these herbs thus provides an overall enhanced benefit for relaxation and stress-reduction.
Moreover, the use of herbal remedies has been gaining popularity in recent years due to their natural and safe effects on the body. The increasing demand for these remedies has led to more research and studies being conducted on the benefits of herbs. This has resulted in the discovery of new combinations of herbs that can provide relief for a variety of health issues such as anxiety, insomnia, and depression.
It is important to note, however, that the use of herbs should always be done with caution and under the guidance of a healthcare professional. While herbs are generally considered safe, they can interact with certain medications and cause adverse effects. Therefore, it is crucial to consult a healthcare professional before trying any new herbal remedy or combining different herbs.
In herbology, herbs are believed to have varying combinations and degrees of qualities. For instance, an herb can be both heating and drying, or heating and moistening. Alternatively, it can be cooling and drying, or cooling and moistening. Furthermore, one herb can be very warming, while another may be only slightly warming. However, both are still considered heating herbs.
Assigning qualities to plants is a simple process. Heating herbs, such as anise and caraway, are believed to produce warmth in the body. Similarly, all aromatic herbs are considered warming. Many bitter herbs, like Oregon grape, are also classified as heating.
Herbs that contain highly volatile oils, such as wintergreen or spearmint, are classified as cooling. Borage is another example of a cooling herb, which is also known as a refrigerant.

Whether an herb is classified as moistening or drying depends on its individual properties. An herb that increases urination, such as bearberry, is considered drying. Astringent herbs, like oak bark or sage, are also called drying. Usually, aromatics like anise or caraway are thought of as drying, but there are exceptions. Fennel, for example, is regarded as moistening because it is said to increase milk production in lactating women. An herb is also considered moistening if it is mucilaginous or demulcent, meaning it has soothing properties. Flax seed, marshmallow, licorice, and slippery elm are good examples of this type of moistening herb.

European herbalists developed a better understanding of herbal properties by identifying which parts of the body were influenced by each herb. They defined specific "centers of activity" in the body for each herb. For example, cayenne pepper, which is classified as a heating herb, affects the circulatory system by increasing the flow of blood, especially to the capillaries near the surface of the skin. This may explain why people who live in hot climates use hot peppers in their cooking. The peppers may help dissipate body heat by circulating it to the skin surface, where it causes cooling as perspiration evaporates and heat radiates into the surrounding air

Is there a difference between a drug and a medicinal herb?

Yes, an herb is a plant that is used for medicinal purposes and is prepared in a specific manner. A drug is a synthesized or man-made copy of one chemical component found in a medicinal herb, produced by a chemical process. In this lesson, you will review these components.

Some herbalists prefer using the whole herb, meaning all parts of the plant - the roots, fruit, petals, leaves, etc. They believe that using the natural material helps the body digest and absorb the herbs, resulting in fewer side-effects.

Believe it or not, synthetic drugs can be derived from herbs. Aspirin, for example, came from white willow bark, as did many others. Nowadays, aspirin is synthesized to produce the drug in mass quantities and for longer shelf life, rather than relying on your own white willow tree in your front yard and preparing the bark as needed.

Herbs contain hundreds or even thousands of naturally occurring chemical components. Scientists and herbalists often use the phrase "active component" to refer to the "active" ingredient of an herb. This is useful to scientists when standardizing an herb or when testing it for quality.

Pharmaceutical companies may make the mistake of extracting only the active component from a herb, without extracting the herb's other naturally occurring ingredients, or making a synthetic copy of the active component. The true "three-fold" (meaning having several parts, or, in this case, several active and non-active components that work together) active ingredients may not be present to interact with each other. As a result, the final product may be far from what nature produced and may cause side effects. This is why different pharmaceutical companies have different production processes.

HERBS ARE NOT DRUG SUBSTITUTES

As more people become aware of the dangerous side-effects of drugs, and with increased awareness of natural and herbal supplements, I am often asked to recommend a natural or herbal supplement as an alternative to a drug.

It is important to note that herbs do not replace prescription or OTC drugs. Herbs and supplements take a while to build up in the body's system in order to provide support, whereas prescription and OTC drugs work quickly. This course is not intended to suggest or recommend any natural or herbal substitute for prescription or OTC drugs. However, a holistic nutritional and health plan can help the body start to heal itself and, hopefully, reduce the need for OTC drugs, or at least the majority of them.

Drugs cover up or suppress symptoms without curing or changing the root cause of the illness. With the symptoms suppressed, the disease or illness is allowed to progress in a modified way.

Natural suggestions and herbal supplements, when used correctly, can address the root cause of the symptoms. Most natural remedies or herbs are not great at suppressing symptoms, and for this reason, they are considered a slower method and a poor substitute for prescription drugs. However, with time, dedication, prayer, and the holistic health and nutrition plan, herbs can support and aid the body in providing the foundation for it to begin to heal itself.

atural preparations and herbal supplements should be used as part of a complete natural nutrition holistic program that includes lifestyle and diet changes designed to improve overall health. The overall plan should be a special, systemized natural health plan that is created for each individual's needs. The whole individual is supported, meaning the soul, mind, will, emotions, and flesh, not just the symptoms. This is known as "holism."

CHEMISTRY OF HERBS

An herbalist only needs to have a basic understanding of the pharmacology of herbs, which are used for their phytochemicals. Scientists have studied the components of herbs extensively, organizing them according to chemical groups. Herbs contain a wide variety of chemicals, such as water, inorganic salts, sugars, carbohydrates, proteins, and alkaloids, to name a few.

Organic acids, including citric acid and chain acids, are found in herbs. Plant acids like valeric acid have sedative properties, while ring acids like benzoic acid have antiseptic properties and are found in foods like cranberries, resins, and balsams. Alcohol is also found in herbs, usually in the form of volatile oils or sterols, such as geraniol in attar of rose and menthol in peppermint oil. Volatile oils, which are a combination of molecules like isoprene or isopentane, are mostly found in aromatic plants and are used to manufacture perfumes. Aromatic oils like eucalyptus oil, garlic oil, and thyme oil are antiseptics.

Carbohydrates are found in a variety of foods, including sugar, fructose, glucose, and starches. Pectin in fruits, algin in seaweeds, gums, and mucilage like coltsfoot, plantain, and marshmallow are also carbohydrates. Phenolic compounds, which are found in plants, function as antiseptics, painkillers, and anti-inflammatories, such as salicylic acid. Tannins in herbs act as astringents to protect the skin and mucous membrane and are also used for external applications like treating burns, healing wounds, and reducing inflammation. Coumarins, found in plants like rhubarb, yellow dock, senna, aloe, and buckthorn, are laxatives and natural dyes. Flavones and flavonoids glycosides, found in buckwheat, bioflavonoid, milk thistle, and other plants, can act as anti-spasmodics, diuretics, circulatory and cardiac stimulants. Saponins, found in primrose, mullein, violet, daisy, and other plants, are utilized in the synthesis of cortisone as well as sex hormones. Cardiac glycosides, found in the lily of the valley, squill, foxglove, and strophanthus family, are made of a mixture of sugar and steroidal aglycone. Bitter principles, found in hops, valerian, white horehound, devil’s claw, marigold, and other plants, have properties like sedatives, cough remedies, and anti-inflammatory herbs. Finally, alkaloids are the most powerful group of plant components and are found in most herbs, storing excessive nitrogen.

CONSTITUENTS & ACTIVE PRINCLIPLES

The distinction between primary and secondary plant metabolism is important in understanding the functions of different plant substances. While primary metabolism products maintain vital plant functions, secondary metabolism products have a protective function against damage, waste storage, and pest and disease control. Some secondary plant substances are also pharmacologically active, making them useful in the development of drugs.

It is worth noting that, while carbohydrates, fats, and proteins are important nutrients for humans and animals, they are not frequently used as pharmacologically active substances. However, they can still have an impact on the efficacy of active principles in drugs.

Secondary plant substances serve a variety of functions. For example, many protect plants from pests, store waste products or act as waste products. Others are pharmacologically active and have potential for use in medicines.

Examples of primary metabolism products include pectins, which are carbohydrates found in many kinds of fruit, especially when unripe. They have a high water-binding capacity and cannot be digested by endogenous intestinal juices. Pectins are useful in the treatment of diarrhea because they lower the pH of the bowel and encourage the growth of beneficial bacteria while producing less favorable living conditions for the pathological bacteria that cause diarrhea. Essential omega-3 and omega-6 fatty acids are fats used in the synthesis of tissue hormones of the eicosanoid, prostaglandin, and thromboxane groups. These hormones are involved in inflammation and related symptoms.

Secondary metabolism products come in many forms. Alkaloids, for example, are pharmacologically active substances found in nightshades such as belladonna, bittersweet, and thornapple, but also in papaveraceae plants (opium poppy, greater celandine), the borage family (coltsfoot, comfrey), and the spea family (Crotalaria). Essential oils, on the other hand, are complex mixtures of compounds found in a variety of plants such as conifers and members of the mint and parsley families. They are used in bath salts and liniments.

Other examples of secondary metabolism products include bitter substances, carotenoids, flavonoids, tannins, glycosides, phytosterols, saponins, mucilage, and mustard oils. Bitter substances stimulate the reflex production of gastrointestinal secretions via lingual taste buds and are indicated for the treatment of dyspeptic complaints and to stimulate appetite and improve digestion and assimilation of nutrients.

Carotenoids act as antioxidants and immunomodulators and are vitamin A precursors. Flavonoids have a nonspecific protective effect on the capillaries, stabilize the cell membrane, and have anticonvulsant and diuretic effects, making them useful in the treatment of varicose veins, inflammations, edema, dyspeptic complaints, liver disorders, and to stimulate bile secretion.

Tannins, on the other hand, irreversibly link protein chains and have an astringent action on the skin and mucous membranes. They have anti-inflammatory, styptic, counterirritant, and weakly antibacterial effects and prevent the excess secretion of mucus. They are indicated for irritations of the skin and mucous membranes and for acute nonspecific diarrhea. Glycosides contain one or multiple sugar molecules as well as a nonsugar component that determines their pharmacological activity. They are indicated for cardiac failure, constipation, and to improve the circulation.

Phytosterins occupy cholesterol receptors and thus lower cholesterol levels. They also stabilize cell walls and inhibit the synthesis of mediators of inflammation. They are indicated to counteract elevated concentrations of lipids and for treatment of benign prostatic hyperplasia. Saponins induce local tissue irritation and reflex expectoration, inhibit the growth of microorganisms, especially fungi, and have partial anti-inflammatory and antiedematous effects. They are indicated to emulsify watery and oily solutions and to promote the dissolution of substances that are not easily absorbed. Mucilage is used to soothe irritated mucous membranes of the mouth, throat, and gastrointestinal tract, to alleviate dry cough, and to regulate the bowels. Mustard oils have antibacterial effects and induce hyperemia of the skin, making them useful in external applications to increase blood flow.

THE ACTION OF HERBS

If you find it difficult to pronounce these words, use Google Lens to read them to you or simply Google the word for its pronunciation. Don't focus too much on this in the beginning of your studies.

Alterative

Alternatives are herbs that will gradually restore the function of the body. They were at one time known as 'blood cleansers'.

Bladderwrack • Bloodroot • Blue Flag • Bogbean • Burdock • Cleavers • Echinacea • Figwort • Fringetree • Fumitory • Garlic • Guaiacum • Goldenseal • Mountain Grape • Nettles • Pasque Flower • Poke Root • Queen's Delight • Red Clover • Sarsaparilla • Sassafras • Wild Indigo • Yellow Dock.

Analgesic, Anodyne

Analgesics are herbs that reduce pain and are either applied externally or internally.

Figwort • Hops • Jamaican Dogwood • Lady's Slipper • Passion Flower • Poppy • Skullcap • St. John's Wort • Valerian.

Anthelmintic

Anthelmintics will destroy or expel worms from the digestive system.

Aloes • Garlic • Pomegranate • Tansy • Thuja • Wormwood • Rue

Anti-microbial

The anti-microbial herbs can help the body to destroy or resist pathogenic microorganisms.

Aniseed • Balsam of Peru • Bearberry • Caraway Oil • Cayenne • Clove • Coriander • Echinacea • Elecampane • Eucalyptus • Garlic • Gentian • Juniper • Marigold • Marjoram • Myrrh • Olive • Peppermint • Plantain • Rosemary • Rue • Sage • Southernwood • Thyme • Wild Indigo • Wormwood.

Antispasmodic

The anti-spasmodics can prevent or ease spasms or cramps in the body.

Black Haw • Black Cohosh • Chamomile • Cramp Bark • Eucalyptus • Lady's Slipper • Lime Blossom • Lobelia • Mistletoe • Motherwort • Pasque Flower • Skullcap • Skunk Cabbage • Thyme • Valerian • Vervain • Wild Lettuce • Wild Yam.

Aperient

Aperient herbs are very mild laxatives.

See 'Laxatives'.

Aromatic

The aromatic herbs have a strong and often pleasant odor and can stimulate the digestive system.

Aniseed •Chinese Angelica • Balm • Basil • Caraway • Cardamom • Celery • Chamomile • Cinnamon • Cloves • Coriander • Dill • Fennel • Hyssop • Ginger • Meadowsweet • Pennyroyal • Peppermint • Rosemary • Valerian • Wood Betony.

Astringent

Astringents bond with tissue by using proteins and can reduce secretions and discharges. They contain tannins.

Agrimony • Avens • Bayberry • Bearberry • Beth Root • Bistort • Black Catechu • Bugleweed • Cranesbill • Elecampane • Eyebright • Goldenrod • Ground Ivy • Kola • Lungwort • Meadowsweet • Mouse Ear • Mullein • Oak Bark • Periwinkle • Pilewort • Plantain • Ragwort • Raspberry • Sage • Rhubarb Root • Rosemary • Slippery Elm • St.John's Wort • Tormentil • Wild Cherry • Witch Hazel • Yarrow.

Bitter

Herbs that taste bitter act as stimulating tonics for the digestive system through a reflex of the taste buds and saliva.

Barberry • Boneset • Chamomile • Centaury • Gentian • Goldenseal • Hops • Rue • Southernwood • Tansy • Horehound • Wormwood.

Cardiac Tonic

Cardiac tonics affect the heart.

Broom • Bugleweed • Cayenne • Hawthorn • Lily of the Valley • Motherwort • Night Blooming Cereus.

Carminative

The carminatives are rich in volatile oils .

Chinese Angelica • Aniseed • Balm • Caraway • Cardamom • Cayenne • Cinnamon • Chamomile • Coriander • Dill • Fennel • Galangal • Garlic • Ginger • Hyssop • Juniper • Mustard • Peppermint • Sage • Thyme • Valerian.

Cholagogue

The cholagogues stimulate the release and secretion of bile from the gall-bladder, and act as a laxative.

Balmony • Barberry • Black Root • Blue Flag • Boldo • Dandelion • Fringetree • Fumitory • Gentian • Goldenseal • Mountain Grape • Wahoo • Wild Yam.

Demulcent

Demulcents are usually rich in mucilage .

Coltsfoot • Comfrey • Corn Silk • Couch Grass • Flaxseed • Irish Moss • Lungwort • Licorice • Mallow • Marshmallow • Mullein • Oatmeal • Parsley • Slippery Elm.

Diaphoretic

Diaphoretics aid the skin in the elimination of toxins and promote sweating.

Chinese Angelica • Bayberry • Black Cohosh • Boneset • Buchu • Cayenne • Chamomile • Elder • Fennel • Garlic • Ginger • Goldenrod • Guaiacum • Lime Blossom • Peppermint • Pleurisy Root • Prickly Ash • Thuja • Thyme • Horehound • Yarrow.

Diuretic

Diuretics increase the secretion and elimination of urine.

Agrimony • Bearberry • Blue Flag • Boldo • Boneset • Borage • Broom • Buchu • Bugleweed • Burdock • Celery Seed • Cleavers • Corn Silk • Couch Grass • Dandelion • Elder • Gravel Root • Hawthorn Berries • Juniper • Kola • Lily of the Valley • Lime Blossom • Night Blooming Cereus • Parsley • Pellitory of the Wall • Pumpkin Seed • Saw Palmetto • Sea Holly • Stone Root • Wild Carrot • Yarrow.

Emetic

Emetics cause vomiting.

Balm • Bloodroot • Boneset • Catnip • Elder Flowers • Ipecacuanha • Lobelia • Senega • Squill.

Emmenagogue

Emmenagogues stimulate the female uterus.

Beth Root • Black Cohosh • Black Haw • Blessed Thistle • Blue Cohosh • Carline Thistle • Chamomile • Chaste Tree • Cramp Bark • False Unicorn Root • Fenugreek • Gentian • Ginger • Goldenseal • Juniper Berry • Lime • Marigold • Motherwort • Mugwort • Parsley • Pasque Flower • Pennyroyal • Peppermint • Raspberry • Rosemary • Rue • Sage • Shepherd's Purse • Southernwood • Squaw Vine • St. John's Wort • Tansy • Thyme • True Unicorn Root • Valerian • Vervain • Wormwood • Yarrow.

Emollient

Emollients are applied to the skin to soften, soothe or protect the skin.

Balm of Gilead • Borage • Chickweed • Coltsfoot • Comfrey • Elecampane • Fenugreek • Flaxseed • Licorice • Mallow • Marshmallow • Mullein • Plantain • Quince Seed • Rose Petals • Slippery Elm.

Expectorant

The expectorants support the body in the removal of excess amounts of mucus from the respiratory system.

Aniseed • Balm of Gilead • Balsam of Peru • Balsam of Tolu • Bloodroot • Coltsfoot • Comfrey • Elder Flower • Elecampane • Garlic • Goldenseal • Grindelia • Hyssop • Iceland Moss • Irish Moss • Licorice • Lobelia • Lungwort • Marshmallow • Mouse Ear • Mullein • Pleurisy Root • Senega • Skunk Cabbage • Squill • Thuja • Thyme • Vervain • Horehound • Wild Cherry.

Febrifuge • Antipyretic

The febrifuges help the body to bring down fevers.

Chinese Angelica • Balm • Blessed Thistle • Boneset • Borage • Cayenne • Elder Flower • Eucalyptus • Hyssop • Lobelia • Marigold • Onion Pennyroyal • Peppermint • Peruvian Bark • Plantain • Pleurisy Root • Prickly Ash • Raspberry • Sage • Thyme • Vervain.

Galactagogue

The galactogogues can help the breast-feeding mother to increase the flow of mother's milk.

Aniseed • Blessed Thistle • Centaury • Fennel • Goat's Rue • Raspberry • Vervain.

Hepatic

The hepatics aid the liver. Their use tones and strengthens it and increases the flow of bile from the liver.

Agrimony • Aloes • Balm • Balmony • Barberry • Black Root • Blue Flag • Boldo • Bogbean • Cascara Sagrada • Celery • Centaury • Cleavers • Dandelion • Elecampane • Fennel • Fringetree • Fumitory • Gentian • Goldenseal • Horseradish • Hyssop • Mountain Grape • Motherwort • Prickly Ash • Wahoo • Wild Indigo • Wild Yam • Wormwood • Yarrow • Yellow Dock.

Hypnotic

Hypnotics will induce sleep.

Hops • Jamaican Dogwood • Mistletoe • Passion Flower • Skullcap • Valerian • Wild Lettuce.

Laxative

The laxatives promote the elimination of the bowels.

Balmony • Barberry • Buckthorn • Burdock • Cascara Sagrada • Cleavers • Dandelion • Flaxseed • Fringetree • Mountain Grape • Pellitory of the Wall • Rhubarb Root • Senna • Wahoo • Yellow Dock.

Mucilage

The mucilaginous herbs contain gelatinous constituents and will often be demulcent and emollient.

Comfrey • Fenugreek • Flaxseed • Iceland Moss • Irish Moss • Mallow • Marshmallow • Quince Seed • Slippery Elm.

Nervine

The nervines have a beneficial effect on the nervous system and tone and strengthen it. Some act as stimulants, some as relaxants.

Balm • Black Cohosh • Black Haw • Blue Cohosh • Bugleweed • Chamomile • Cramp Bark • Damiana • Ginseng • Hops • Kola • Lady's Slipper • Lavender • Lemon Balm • Lime • Lobelia • Mistletoe • Motherwort • Oats • Pasque Flower • Passion Flower • Peppermint • Red Clover • Rosemary • Skullcap • Tansy • Thyme • Valerian • Vervain • Wild Lettuce • Wormwood.

Oxytocic

The oxytocics stimulate the contraction of the uterus and can thereby help in childbirth.

Beth Root • Blue Cohosh • Goldenseal • Rue • Squaw Vine.

Pectoral

Pectorals have a general strengthening and healing effect on the respiratory system.

Aniseed • Chinese Angelica • Balm of Gilead • Balsam of Peru • Balsam of Tolu • Bloodroot • Coltsfoot • Comfrey • Elder • Elecampane • Garlic • Goldenseal • Horehound • Hyssop • Iceland Moss • Irish Moss • Licorice • Lungwort • Marshmallow • Mouse Ear • Mullein • Pleurisy Root • Senega • Skunk Cabbage • Vervain.

Rubefacient

When rubefacients are applied to the skin they cause a gentle local irritation and stimulate the dilation of the capillaries, thus increasing circulation in the skin.

Cayenne • Cloves • Garlic • Ginger • Horseradish • Mustard • Nettle • Peppermint • Rosemary • Rue.

Sedative

The sedatives calm the nervous system and reduce stress and nervousness throughout the body.

Black Cohosh • Black Haw • Bladderwrack • Blue Cohosh • Bloodroot • Boldo • Bugleweed • Chamomile • Cowslip • Cramp Bark • Hops • Jamaican Dogwood • Lady's slipper • Lobelia • Motherwort • Pasque Flower • Passion Flower • Red Clover • Red Poppy • Saw Palmetto • Skullcap • St. John's Wort • Valerian • Wild Cherry • Wild Lettuce • Wild Yam.

Sialagogue

The sialogogues stimulate the secretion of saliva from the salivary glands.

Bloodroot • Blue Flag • Cayenne • Centaury • Gentian • Ginger • Prickly Ash • Senega.

Soporific

The soporifics induce sleep.

Compare 'Hypnotics'.

Stimulant

Stimulants quicken and refresh the body, giving it a boost.

Chinese Angelica • Balm of Gilead • Balmony • Bayberry • Benzoin • Bladderwrack • Caraway • Cardamom • Cayenne • Cinnamon • Dandelion • Eucalyptus • Galangal • Garlic • Gentian • Ginseng • Gravel Root • Ground Ivy • Horehound • Horseradish • Juniper • Marigold • Mustard • Pennyroyal • Peppermint • Prickly Ash • Rosemary • Rue • Sage • Southernwood • Tansy • Wild Yam • Wormwood • Yarrow.

Styptic

Styptics reduce or stop external bleeding by their astringency.

Tonic

The tonic herbs strengthen either certain organs or the entire body.

Agrimony • Chinese Angelica • Aniseed • Balm • Balmony • Bayberry • Bearberry • Beth Root • Bistort • Black Cohosh • Black Haw • Black Root • Bogbean • Boldo • Boneset • Buchu • Buckthorn • Bugleweed • Burdock • Calumba • Carline Thistle • Cayenne • Centaury • Chamomile • Cleavers • Coltsfoot • Comfrey • Condurango • Couch Grass • Cranesbill • Damiana • Dandelion • Echinacea • Elecampane • Eyebright • False UniCorn Root • Fringetree • Fumitory • Garlic • Gentian • Ginseng • Goldenseal • Gravel Root • Grindelia • Ground Ivy • Hawthorn • Horse Chestnut • Hydrangea • Hyssop • Iceland Moss • Lady's Slipper • Licorice • Lime • Marigold • Mistletoe • Motherwort • Mountain Grape • Mugwort • Mustard • Myrrh • Nettle • Oats • Parsley • Periwinkle • Poke Root • Raspberry • Red Clover • Rue • Sarsaparilla • Skullcap • Squaw Vine • Tamarind • Tansy • Thyme • Vervain • Virginia Snake Root • Wild Yam • Wood Betony • Wormwood • Yarrow • Yellow Dock.

Vulnerary

Vulneraries are applied externally and aid the body in the healing of wounds and cuts.

Aloes • Arnica • Bistort • Black Willow • Burdock • Calendula •Chickweed • Cleavers • Comfrey • Cranesbill • Daisy • Elder • Elecampane • Fenugreek • Flaxseed • Garlic • Goldenseal • Horsetail • Hyssop • Irish Moss • Marigold • Marshmallow • Mullein • Myrrh • Plantain • Poke Root • Shepherd's Purse • Slippery Elm • St. John's Wort • Thyme • Witch Hazel • Wood Betony • Yarrow.

DANGERS, EFFECTIVENSS, & INTERACTIONS

Effectiveness- Most herbal preparations take time to build up in one system and work. Herbs however will not cure, heal, or treat; they only provide support to the body to heal itself.

Medical Interaction

It is crucial to consult with a licensed physician before using herbal remedies and supplements, as some of them may interact with drugs, including over-the-counter drugs. The negative consequences of combining an herbal remedy that lowers blood pressure with prescription medicine that has the same effect can be quite serious, resulting in dangerously low blood pressure. For instance, ylang ylang is known to lower blood pressure, and therefore, it is important to exercise caution while using it.

Moreover, it is advisable to avoid many herbs during pregnancy to ensure the safety of both the mother and the child. However, not all physicians may be well-versed in the effects of different types of herbal medicine. Therefore, it becomes our responsibility to take control of our health and acquire as much information as possible to make informed decisions. In this regard, www.drugs.com can be a useful resource to research drug interactions between herbs and drugs.

It is important to remember that while herbal preparations and supplements can provide a natural approach to healing, it is crucial to use them with care and under professional guidance. Taking the necessary precautions and making informed decisions can help ensure a safe and effective use of these remedies.



HERBAL

PREPARATIONS







HERBAL PREPARATIONS

Herbalism is often referred to as herbal preparation, and 'alternative medicine' is defined in the dictionary as the use of remedies such as homeopathy or naturopathy that are not considered part of the mainstream of medicine. However, in different parts of the world, 'alternative medicine' is considered the norm and is the mainstream of medicine, such as in the Western world.

For me, herbalism means traditional herbal preparation. My ancestors practiced herbalism, and licensed physicians would often recommend herbal remedies for various respiratory problems, the flu, and other ailments. As a child, I remember being told to use Plantain for bee stings when out in the field. Therefore, I believe it is important for people to take control of their health and not just rely on 'modern medicine' to treat symptoms with drugs and surgery. While 'modern medicine' is necessary in certain life-threatening cases, I think it can be avoided in many cases with the right herbal education and information.

The purpose of this course is to provide you with the knowledge, tools, and resources to make responsible decisions about your own health and the health of those you care for. After all, who knows your body and health better than you? This course is not meant to criticize governments or healthcare systems, but rather to empower individuals to seek the best and most efficient healthcare available. Many other countries, such as Alaska and Europe, have increased the use of herbal pharmaceuticals and are seeing positive results.

In this course, Herbal Medicine will be referred to as an herbal preparation.

HERBAL FORMS

Herbal Teas

There are two methods of making herbal teas: infusion and decoction. Infusion involves steeping lighter parts of the plant (leaves, flowers, and light stems) in boiled water for several minutes. Decoction involves boiling tougher parts, such as roots or bark, for a longer period of time. You will learn more about making medicinal and herbal teas, including the difference between tinctures and decoctions. Not all herbal teas are considered medicinal based on the way the tincture or decoction is prepared.

Herbal Tinctures

Steeping a medicinal plant in alcohol extracts the herbal properties into a liquid form that can be stored for long periods. There are also non-alcoholic tinctures that substitute alcohol with apple cider vinegar.

Herbal Poultices

Poultices use the plant material itself mixed with water and placed into a muslin cloth that is then applied to the skin for a topical remedy. They have the shortest life span of any herbal remedy and must be made fresh for every use.

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Powdered Herbs and Tablets

Herbs that are dried and then diced into a powder can be placed into a vegetable glycerin capsule, or formed into a tablet using a mold to make herbal medicine more convenient.

Herbal Ointments

An ointment or salve or rub is a semi-solid preparation made to be applied to the skin topically. Depending on the purpose for which it is designed and its method of preparation, the texture can vary from very greasy to a thick paste. The simplest ointments use beeswax as a base, along with carrier oil. While some OTC herbal ointments and salves have a hardening agent added in, the best medicinal salves are those that are homemade and contain no synthetic agents.

Essential Oils

Extraction of volatile liquid plant materials and other aromatic compounds from plants produces essential oils. These plant oils may be used internally in some forms of herbal medicine, as well as in aromatherapy and generally for their perfume.

Perfume oils and fragrance oils are not the same as essential oils. It takes several pounds of herbs to make just one bottle of essential oil. There are infused oil methods that can be used as a substitute for using essential oils.

Herbal Supplements

Herbal supplements are commercial products in tablet or capsule form that are made and marketed by the health food industry to sell to the general public. Some supplements and products are only sold to licensed healthcare professionals as a prescription. Herbal supplements are standardized, meaning they are formulated to contain levels of active phytochemicals.

However, many herbalists prefer to use the whole plant rather than just the targeted phytochemical. When an herb is standardized, the targeted phytochemical is extracted from the plant into pill or liquid form, leaving the rest of the plant's properties and other essential phytochemicals behind.

In the US, most herbal remedies are considered dietary supplements. However, not all supplements are true to their label. The Food and Drug Administration (FDA) regulates all healthcare products and herbal supplements. However, the FDA treats homeopathic remedies differently than conventional medicines. Homeopathic products do not need FDA approval before sale, and they do not have to be proven safe or effective. They do not have to be labeled with an expiration date, and they do not have to undergo finished product testing to verify contents, strength, or potency. Many herbs for home use can be grown in a small home garden. However, the government is working to get the FDA to test and study the herbal and homeopathic supplements that are on the market.

Herbal Forms in Detail

There are many different kinds of herbal preparation available, but the best ones are the ones that can be done right at home. This document provides information on various preparations for internal use.

Infusions

Infusions are hot water extracts made from dried or fresh herbs, preferably the leaves and blooms. The most common infusion is making tea. To make an infusion, steep 1/2 to 1 ounce of dried herbs in hot boiling water for 10 to 20 minutes, then strain with a cheesecloth or muslin cloth into another glass jar or container. Infusions should be made as needed since they do not have a long shelf life. For medicinal purposes, some herbalists like to take 2 teaspoons of dried herbs per cup of boiling water that is 8 oz cup to 1 or 2 rounded tsp of dried herbs. After 20 minutes, the infusion is no longer hot, so making a large amount of infusion to drink will need to be reheated. To make a medicinal tea or infusion, place herbs in a muslin tea bag and simmer for 10 minutes, then add another tsp of herbs in the infusion water and simmer for another 10 minutes to increase the potency of the herb infusion. Infusions can also be made in a coffee pot for faster preparation.

Decoctions

Decoctions are similar to infusions but are made from the roots and bark of the herb. Roots and bark take a longer time to expel their medicinal properties. To make a decoction, bring the water and herb mixture to a boil, reduce the heat, and allow it to simmer for around 20 minutes (no less than 10), then strain and store.

Syrups

Infusions and decoctions can be added to syrups. To make a syrup, mix 12 ounces or 325 grams of sugar into 600 ml of liquid and heat until the sugar has dissolved. Cool and store the syrup in a refrigerator. Once you weigh the infusion or decoction, you can add a quarter of its weight of honey into it. Heat slowly and bring it down to a thick liquid, and remove the scum that can form on top of the liquid mixture. An alternative preparation involves boiling 1 pint of water, adding over 2.5 lbs or 1,25 kg of brown sugar, and stirring it over low heat until the sugar dissolves completely and the solution is boiling. After it is removed from the heat, add 1 part of herbal tincture to 3 parts of syrup and set aside.

Tinctures

Tinctures are made from herbal infusion with alcohol, usually vodka, gin, or brandy. To prepare a tincture, use 1 part of dry herb to 5 parts of liquid, and if they are fresh herbs, use 1 part of herbs to 2 parts of liquid. Place all the herbs in a big jar and pour the alcohol and water in it, leave it aside to mix, shaking it 2 times a day for 2 weeks only. Press out the liquid and throw the herbs. Store in dark bottles or glass jars kept away from heat and light and make sure they are labeled. Non-alcoholic tinctures can be made with warm but not boiled apple cider vinegar instead of water. You can make alcohol tinctures using vodka or brandy, but it's not recommended. Vegetable glycerin tinctures, known as glycosides, or syrups can be made as well in place of alcoholic tinctures.

Suppositories

Suppositories can be prepared with ease at home. Add finely powdered dried herbs to melted cocoa butter and pour this mixture into molds, allowing it to cool for some time. You can store it in the refrigerator, and it can be packed in aluminum foil. Vegetable glycerin with a little beeswax can be done as well for a suppository.

Tablets and capsules

Capsules are powdered herbs packed inside a vegetable glycerin capsule or gelatin capsule. Capsules come in different sizes, so before making them, please read about capsule sizes and recommended dosages for each herb. Capsule making also requires a little plastic pill making equipment. Though herb tablets and capsules are available in herbal shops or health food shops, they can be easily made at home too. The capsules can be made at home by utilizing gel capsules and filling them with the herb mixtures. If you use a capsule maker, then you can make larger quantities, and the process is much easier. There are two standard capsule sizes, which are 0 and 00. Size 0 can hold approximately 0.35 grams of powdered mixture for a person to consume 3 tablets to be taken 3 times a day according to the suggested intake plan. Size 00 can hold 0.5 grams of the powdered mixture for two capsules to be taken 3 times a day on a daily basis of the suggested intake plant.